

Unit 4: Autonomy and Self-Worth

The final unit of the curriculum gives participants tools and assessments for cultivating balanced lives and relationships. Managing stress, negative emotions, and negative self-talk are discussed and considered.

Unit themes and guiding questions:

- How can I cultivate traits of assertiveness, independence, and confidence that are rooted in an understanding of my value?
- How do I maintain healthy boundaries and manage stress?

Lesson 1: Stress Management and Self-Care

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

This is the beginning of a new unit on self-worth. In this session, we'll be tackling the subjects of stress and self-care, and responding to stress to avoid negative consequences.

Life Stress Inventory Assessment

Have students individually take the Holmes-Rahe Life Stress Inventory Assessment Social Readjustment Rating Scale (SRRS) or a similar assessment that measures the relationship between stress and life changes. Here are some online sources:

- **Holmes-Rahe Stress Inventory – Social Readjustment Rating Scale (SRRS)**
(American Institute of Stress): <https://www.stress.org/holmes-rahe-stress-inventory>
- **Holmes-Rahe Stress Inventory – Social Readjustment Rating Scale (SRRS)**
(SimplyPsychology.org): <https://www.simplypsychology.org/srrs.html>

- **Other stress questionnaires** (American Institute of Stress):
<https://www.stress.org/self-assessment>

Large Group

- What did you notice about the inventory?
- Did anything surprise you as you filled it out?
- What does it feel like when you're stressed?
- What do you do when you're stressed?

Individual Reflection

Through the stress inventory, we've looked at some of the life events and social factors that can stress us out. In the midst of all the stressors that can impact our lives, it can be really difficult to maintain the healthy patterns we've discussed. On your own, I want you to think of a stressful situation you've dealt with in the past, and the way you responded to that stressful situation.

Large Group

- What are some positive ways you've dealt with stress?
- What are ways you've dealt with stress that didn't have positive outcomes for you or the people around you?
- What are some strategies you can employ for better stress management?

We can never truly control our lives, but we can control our responses to stressful situations. One strategy we can use is self-care. Self-care involves thinking of the ways you can best care for and protect yourself, your mental and physical health, and lower your stress. Self-care is not a fix-all or a quick fix, but it is something that you have control over.

When I am stressed, one of my methods for self-care is:

[Facilitator, provide an example true to you, as long as it is a constructive, healthy practice. Maybe you take a yoga class, sing Broadway songs in an extra long shower, make sure you're getting a full 8 hours of sleep a night, get your weekly manicure, or practice deep breathing and meditation. If there are interns present, ask them to provide an example as well.]

Let's brainstorm a list of small ways that you can take care of yourself and alleviate stress.

Brainstorm

Use a large pad of paper or a dry-erase board to write suggestions in a visible place for the group. Ask them to call out ideas for productive, healthy self-care strategies like the one you mentioned above.

Questions for consideration:

- *Can you incorporate one or more of these techniques in your daily life?*
- *What would it look like if you attempted one of these practices when you were feeling stressed, angry, or frustrated?*
- *How do you think it would feel to make caring for yourself a priority?*
- *Who benefits when you care for yourself? (Emphasis on the answer: you, and everyone around you! Your partner, family, and kids are all better for your good mental health practices.)*
- *Do you have any questions about self-care?*

Lesson 2: Healthy Boundaries and Communication

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

Learning about different communication styles is really important for thinking about how we maintain healthy boundaries. How we articulate our boundaries can contribute to how others understand and respect them. So today we're going to review three different styles of communication: passive, assertive, and aggressive. These different styles tend to evoke different responses in the people you are communicating with.

Passive Communication

Passive communication can be how some people naturally communicate, and it can also be an effect of experiencing abuse. This type of communication is characterized by understating one's feelings, avoiding direct discussion of one's needs, and refusing to communicate when their boundaries are crossed. People exhibiting this communication style might avoid eye contact, speak softly, or apologize frequently.

Passive communication may avoid conflict in the moment, but it can lead to a variety of consequences. If you don't communicate your needs, the people around you can't read your mind to meet them. The frustration from repressing your needs and desires can lead to blow ups of temper or emotion later. In addition, people who frequently use passive communication styles can feel anxious, and can be hostile or resentful toward the people around them who aren't meeting their unarticulated needs. And, because passive communication avoids conflict, it also avoids the personal growth that comes from healthy, nonabusive conflict.

Assertive Communication

Assertive communication is a balanced communication style. Communicating assertively means you can respectfully and honestly express your needs and feelings to the people you're in relationship or community with, without blaming. That is, people who communicate assertively are in the habit of making "I" statements, rather than blaming "you" statements that avoid accountability. Other habits of assertive communicators include listening actively and attentively, standing up for themselves, and being in control of their emotions and reactions.

That sense of control is an outcome of assertive communication, along with a sense of being well-connected to the people they care about. The respectful environment assertive communicators cultivate serves them in getting their needs met, and serves the people around them in having their needs heard and appreciated as well.

Aggressive Communication

Aggressive communication is a way of communicating that actively disrespects and violates other people. It is characterized by attempts to belittle, humiliate, or dominate other people during conflicts. Those things might sound familiar—they are also characteristics of toxic masculinity and of verbal and emotional abuse.

Aggressive communicators blame, criticize, and attack. They can get loud, angry, and physically aggressive. The result of this kind of communication is alienating themselves from other people, closing off opportunities for real connection and intimacy, and making the people around them afraid and resentful.

Of course, it's very rare that any one person uses one of these styles exclusively. People are much more complicated than that! But our goal is to increase the frequency of assertive communication in your life, and decrease the occurrences of passive or aggressive communication.

We're going to get some practice thinking about these three styles. Take a look at the example on Handout 8, and try to think of three different responses to the situation: one passive, one assertive, and one aggressive response.

Handout 8: Communication and Boundaries

Large Group

- What did you think about Alex crossing Pat's boundaries?
- How might one passively respond to boundaries being crossed that way?
- How might you respond assertively?
- What's an aggressive reaction to boundaries being crossed?

Individual Reflection

Let's take a moment to reflect on our own communication styles in times of conflict. Think of a time in your life where you felt as if your boundaries were violated. Did you use passive, assertive, or aggressive communication in response to that stress? How did the person you were communicating respond? How did you feel afterward? Take a moment to write the story of that moment in your life.

Large Group

- What did you write about?
- Do you notice a pattern about which types of communication you use in your own life?
- What would happen if you tried another kind of communication?

- What types of communication do the people you are close to use?
- How do the different styles of communication make you feel when you're using them? How about when you're exposed to them?
- Do you have any questions about styles of communication?
- Do you have questions about the outcomes of the different styles of communication?

Lesson 3: Cultivating Self-Worth

Icebreaker

Choose an icebreaker from the Icebreaker List.

Lesson Script

Today, we're finishing up our time together by discussing how we can change the stories we tell ourselves about who we are. Sometimes, we can be really hard on ourselves. It's so easy to see the things we don't do well, and a lot harder to see the ways that we show up as a positive force in the world and for the people around us. People involved in domestic violence can experience a lot of shame and guilt, and it can have lasting impacts on their self-esteem, self-worth, and sense of independence and autonomy. We're going to learn a strategy that can aid us when we're feeling like it's hard to see our own value.

Handout 9: Combating Negative Self-Talk

Take a look at the Combating Negative Self-Talk chart. On it, you'll see four different columns.

The first column is labeled "negative thought." These are the thoughts that creep up and make us feel less-than. They might include things like "I'm not good at relationships," "I am worthless," or "I'm damaged goods." Those negative thoughts belong in that column.

The second column asks what feeling that thought produces. So, if your negative thought was, "I'm damaged goods," that might produce a feeling of sadness, bitterness, anger, or loneliness.

The third column is the hardest to think about. This column asks that you re-frame that initial negative thought, and transform it into something positive. Using evidence from your life and experiences, translate the negative thought into a new, empowering one. For example, if we keep using “I’m damaged goods,” as the original thought, a new re-framing might sound like “My tough life experience makes me strong and prepared for anything.” Or maybe, “Nothing other people have done to me has lessened my value.” Or even, “I am not ‘goods,’ or a product. I am a whole person who cannot be damaged like an object.”

The fourth column asks that we reflect on how that new, positive thought makes us feel. Maybe it makes you feel calm, or secure, happy, or proud. It may also make you feel anxious, or doubtful if you’re not used to thinking positively about yourself.

Come up with as many negative thought transformations as you wish in the next few minutes. Prepare to share your process with the larger group.

Large Group Sharing

One at a time, let’s go around the room and share an example or two of negative self-talk that you’ve managed to reframe.

- Can you use this strategy when you have a negative thought about yourself?
- What are some of the hardest thoughts to re-frame? How about the easiest?
- Why should we care about negative thoughts and self-talk?
- Are there any questions about negative self-talk and self-esteem?